

ENTERPRISE PROCUREMENT SERIES

Navigating a Seller's Market as an Enterprise Buyer

A practical guide to infrastructure procurement during global hardware constraints — understanding supply dynamics, managing risk, and building resilient sourcing strategies.

40–60%

PROJECTED ANNUAL
GROWTH IN AI SERVER
SHIPMENTS

20–80%

SSD PRICE INCREASES IN
ENTERPRISE SEGMENTS

3×

SOME SYSTEMS TRIPLED IN
PRICE WITHIN 12 MONTHS

Topics covered in this guide:

Shifting Market Dynamics · AI Infrastructure Demand · Allocation-Driven Supply · Pricing Volatility · Alternative Strategies · Gray Market Risk · 2026 Procurement Checklist

— MARKET OVERVIEW

The Market Has Fundamentally Changed

For many years, enterprise IT procurement operated in a buyer-friendly environment. Hardware was widely available through multiple distribution channels, competition between vendors drove prices downward, and procurement teams had the flexibility to compare options before making decisions.

Today, that landscape has changed dramatically. Demand for compute, storage, and memory components has surged to unprecedented levels — driven by the rapid expansion of AI and high-performance computing environments — while supply chains have struggled to keep pace.

The result is a fundamental shift: many segments of enterprise infrastructure now operate in a **seller's market**. Pricing is less predictable, lead times are longer, and the traditional expectation of immediate availability no longer applies.

Enterprise buyers increasingly encounter allocation programs, constrained supply pipelines, and rapidly fluctuating component costs. Understanding these forces — and adapting procurement strategies accordingly — has become essential.

Key shift: In previous years, procurement teams primarily focused on comparing vendors and negotiating prices. Today's more pressing question: **"Can we source the hardware we need within a required timeframe?"**

— THE AI EFFECT

AI Infrastructure Reshaping Supply

The current hardware environment is being shaped by several overlapping forces, but the most significant is the explosive growth of AI infrastructure. Training and deploying modern AI models requires enormous amounts of compute power, storage throughput, and memory bandwidth.

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COST INCREASE ON SOME
SYSTEMS YEAR-OVER-
YEAR

↑ Alloc

DRAM CAPACITY
INCREASINGLY ALLOCATED
TO HYPERSCALERS

As hyperscale organizations build increasingly large GPU-accelerated server clusters, these deployments consume vast quantities of enterprise components — DRAM, NVMe storage, networking hardware, and specialized accelerators — creating ripple effects throughout the entire technology ecosystem.

Manufacturers Reprioritizing Production

MICRON

Stepping Back from Consumer SSDs

Micron, one of the world's largest memory producers, recently announced its decision to step away from a significant portion of the consumer SSD market — choosing instead to focus more heavily on enterprise and data-center products where hyperscale infrastructure demand continues to grow.

SAMSUNG

Discontinuing SATA SSD Lines

Samsung, long a dominant player in the storage market, indicated it will discontinue production of certain SATA SSD product lines as the industry transitions toward newer storage architectures and enterprise-focused technologies — tightening supply in traditional procurement channels.

— STRATEGIC RESPONSE

Strategies for a Constrained Market

While the current environment presents challenges, organizations still have several effective options. A multi-strategy approach helps ensure infrastructure stability — no single strategy will be appropriate for every organization. The optimal mix depends on existing infrastructure investments, workload requirements, regulatory considerations, and risk tolerance.

①

Lifecycle Extension via Third-Party Maintenance

Many enterprise systems remain technically capable well beyond the end of manufacturer support programs. Through third-party maintenance (TPM) programs, organizations can continue operating critical infrastructure while delaying large capital expenditures until supply conditions improve — typically saving 30–85% vs. OEM support rates.

②

Hybrid Infrastructure Models

Adopting hybrid models that combine on-premise systems with cloud-based resources allows organizations to distribute workloads across multiple environments, maintaining operational flexibility without relying entirely on immediate hardware procurement.

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Hardware Rental Programs

Short-term rental or temporary deployment arrangements offer practical solutions for compute-intensive projects such as AI development or data processing — allowing access to high-performance infrastructure without committing to permanent purchases during volatile pricing periods.

④

Refurbished & Secondary Market Hardware

Certified refurbished enterprise hardware from reputable suppliers offers a cost-effective alternative to new equipment, with tested and validated components backed by warranty and replacement assurances — without the risks of unvetted gray market sources.

⑤

Cloud Migration for Capacity Expansion

For organizations seeking short-term capacity expansion, cloud platforms can provide immediate compute resources that may be difficult to obtain on-premise during supply shortages — though this approach is not suitable for every workload or highly regulated environment.

⑥

Hardware Redeployment

When hardware becomes insufficient for one task, consider redeploying it elsewhere in the organization. This maximizes the value of existing investments, reduces unnecessary procurement, and extends the effective service life of infrastructure assets.

Organizations that combine **lifecycle extension**, **hybrid deployments**, **flexible sourcing**, and **strategic partnerships** are best positioned to navigate today's evolving infrastructure landscape. Deploy each strategy where it works best — there is no universal solution.

— RISK AWARENESS

Understanding Gray Market Risk

In a constrained supply environment, many organizations turn to the gray market to source hardware more quickly or at lower cost — but this approach comes with important trade-offs.

⚠️ GRAY MARKET TRADE-OFFS TO UNDERSTAND

Gray market products may include overproduced OEM units without official serial numbers, refurbished hardware tied to another customer's warranty, or outright component replicas. While these may function similarly, they often lack OEM-recognized serial numbers — restricting access to official support, firmware updates, and licensing. This creates downstream challenges in environments relying on software entitlements or vendor-backed service agreements.

| When It May Be Acceptable

In certain cases, gray market sourcing can be a practical option for non-critical or purely physical components like drive trays. For these lower-risk items, a cost-benefit approach may be reasonable with proper due diligence.

| When to Avoid It

For core infrastructure — GPUs, storage drives, memory — the hidden risks can far outweigh upfront savings. Always verify serial numbers with the OEM, confirm support and licensing eligibility, and understand the equipment's origin before proceeding.

PROCUREMENT CHECKLIST

Enterprise Procurement Checklist for 2026

As infrastructure markets continue to evolve, enterprise buyers should consider the following steps when planning procurement strategies. Use this checklist as a starting point for evaluating your current approach and identifying gaps.

- ✓ Evaluate third-party maintenance programs to extend the life of existing infrastructure and reduce OEM dependency
- ✓ When hardware becomes insufficient for a primary task, identify opportunities to redeploy it elsewhere within the organization
- ✓ Consider certified refurbished enterprise hardware where appropriate — validate serial numbers, warranties, and support eligibility
- ✓ Build multiple sourcing channels rather than relying on a single vendor or distribution partner
- ✓ Maintain flexible infrastructure strategies that combine on-premise and cloud resources to adapt to shifting conditions
- ✓ Evaluate short-term or long-term hardware rental options for capacity expansion during peak demand or supply shortages
- ✓ Monitor memory, storage, and component markets for pricing and availability shifts on a regular basis
- ✓ Strengthen cybersecurity practices when extending infrastructure lifecycles — older hardware requires proper patching and monitoring
- ✓ Establish relationships with infrastructure partners who have established networks across OEMs, distributors, and secondary markets
- ✓ Develop a documented procurement contingency plan that addresses supply disruption scenarios before they occur

LOOKING AHEAD

The Path Forward

The recent surge in AI-driven demand has stretched the global infrastructure market thin, and these conditions will take time to resolve — especially as demand continues to grow. Memory manufacturers, storage vendors, and system integrators are adjusting production strategies, but the transition will take time.

Organizations that diversify their infrastructure strategies — combining lifecycle extension, hybrid deployments, flexible sourcing, and strategic partnerships — will be better positioned to navigate the evolving technology landscape.

Staying informed and maintaining adaptable procurement strategies will be key to long-term success. The good

In the meantime, enterprise buyers must adapt to a procurement environment where planning, flexibility, and strategic sourcing play a larger role than in the past.

news: organizations do not need to navigate these challenges alone.

— GET STARTED

Ready to Build a Resilient Procurement Strategy?

Dataknox Solutions works with enterprise IT teams to develop practical, flexible procurement strategies tailored to specific infrastructure requirements, timelines, and budget constraints. If you are evaluating your next steps or facing supply limitations, we welcome the opportunity to share perspective, assess your current environment, and help identify the most effective path forward.



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